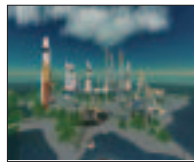


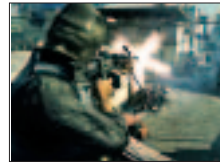
Brit Couple Divorces Over Second Life

A British couple has sought divorce after the wife spotted her husband getting jiggy with someone else in *Second Life*. The unrepentant and adulterous husband declared he didn't love his wife anymore. The wife, Amy Taylor, later found love on *World of Warcraft*



Geeks Beat Marines At War Game

At the debut of the new game — *World at War* — the world watched as an innocuous teenager wiped out an elite squad of marines in the game. And these aren't computer-generated marines, either — they were real, flesh-and-blood marines playing the game



Escape

IDENTITY CRISIS

OpenID Too Much To Take

When you sign into your Gmail account, you're automatically signed into all Google Services — Docs, Blogger, Reader, whatever. And you like that, don't you? We do too. It's hassle-free, and hassle-free is good indeed. But then, you need another ID for your Yahoo! account. And another for your Windows Live services. And another for some other services we can't really think of right now.

And then came OpenID — the initiative that promised us a single ID. If you remember just one single password, you're set to access all the services you ever need. It's more hassle-free than what we're used to now, so it can only be better.

In January this year, there were only two players supporting the platform — Yahoo! and AOL. And we don't know about you, but we remember sticking to our Yahoo! IDs to access the services. Now, however, more of the big guns have joined the movement for OpenID — Google, MySpace and Microsoft, among others, announced their support for the platform in October. Finally, it looks like the way is paved for a Web that's much easier to access, and henceforth, we'll only have just one ID to remember. Even better, you



already have an OpenID — none of this registration nonsense to contend with.

Only one problem, though: people don't seem to be using it.

It's not that people aren't enthusiastic about it, either — you're probably getting pretty excited about OpenID yourself, we can tell — it's just that they can't figure it out. When Yahoo! studied the success of their OpenID system, they saw one critical flaw with it — users found the system absolutely befuddling. But is it really that befuddling, or are we talking stupid users here?

Turns out, logging into a service with an OpenID is considerably befuddling indeed. First, there's the matter of your ID. You don't register for one: if you have some sort of Web presence — Blogger or Yahoo!, for example — you already have an OpenID. In the former case, it's your blog address; in the latter, it's a little complicated. Then there's the login process itself. It

isn't as simple as username: password any more. Let's say you want to use your Blogger address as your OpenID. You just enter your blog URL in the box that asks for your OpenID, and click on Login. Then, you'll be taken to Blogger, where you'll have to log in using your Google ID. And then, you'll go back to the site you were trying to log into, and you'll be signed in. Dizzy yet? And the process changes for every OpenID-toting service, too.

And we know what you're thinking — unless the companies get their act together and stop sending us bouncing around the Internet, we'll keep our passwords, thank you.

BOOM, LIKE THAT

Total Recall

Even as we complacently sit with our...well...laps, we forget the horrors of days past. Days when no lap was safe. When any normal day could turn to horror as the most innocuous of components — the humble battery — took to revenge. All over the world, they launched kamikaze attacks, going up in flames, and taking with them precious laptops, their data, and sometimes even human flesh. The world of

Whatever Happened To... The Trackball

Ah, the good old days — when mice had balls, and you'd waste the first few minutes of your work day cleaning them.

Between the mechanical and optical mouse, there was one device that promised to end the era of dirty mechanical mice, and more importantly, counter the effects that these mice were having on our wrists. We remember all the hype — even the big features in your favourite technology magazine. And then, nothing.

While we'd like to say that the optical mouse was the trackball's undoing, the problem (if you can really call it that) ran deeper. Trackballs have been around for ages — even before mice — so there must be some other explanation. It's simple enough, really — they just aren't everyone's cup of tea.

From our own experiences, we've seen that while trackballs were considerably more comfortable and accurate than the old ball-mice, for some of us, they just took the stress from our wrists and gave it to our index fingers. Some others were so used to the mouse that they couldn't fathom anything that didn't need to move around the table. And yes, the optical mouse became the final argument against switching away from the mouse.

Still, the trackball does enjoy its own little cult following, and if you want to see what the fuss is all about, you might still be able to get your hands on one. Logitech still sells its range of trackballs, right from the entry-level PS/2 model. However, it's not just the PC any more — you'll see trackballs or your favourite Blackberrys, and even on the G1.

portable computing was plunged into chaos, as users lost the courage to even turn on their machines. There were fragments of Dell and shards of Apple, and Toshiba cowered in the corner. We take a moment now to remember our electronic friends who perished in those blasts.

And to tell you that the danger hasn't passed. Dell recalled laptops back then, Sony recalled their batteries, there was much criticism, but it hasn't ended. In October, there was another scare, and Sony has now recalled 100,000 more batteries worldwide. That's right, those lithium-ion rogues are still out there, just waiting for the opportunity to take something precious with them. Who will it be this time? Will it be you, guy-who-reads-RSS-feeds-in-bed? Or you, lady-who-does-her-accounts-in-public-transportation? Or will it be Innocent Bystander #54, whose only crime is to appreciate the shiny new laptop in his peripheral vision?

Across the US, owners of HP laptops are in panic, for 32,000 of the 35,000 kamikaze batteries are apparently in HP systems. Sixty-five thousand are spread across the world, hiding out in everything from Dells to Tecras to Toshibas. The war on battery terror isn't over, and it's time to put your laptops back on your tables once again.

BEYOND HELP

Online Psychics Profit

It's no secret that thanks to the naughty antics of the Big American Corporations, the world is in an economic slump, and fear reigns everywhere. In these tough times, we turn to all those wise investments we made over the years, cut down on our unnecessary expenses, and generally find support in our fellow unfortunate friends and family. In the US, however, people are spamming their online psychics.

On September 30 — the day the madness truly began — Katrina Spears, "Internet medium" came home after an errand to find 30 panicked messages from her clients. Since that day, Spears has found herself inundated with online consultations, reassuring panicked Americans that everything will be all right. And at \$3 (Rs 150) a minute, you can bet that she's telling them every single thing they should be happy about.



Another "reader", Pure Empathy, puts it in better perspective: "People are more depressed, and I can easily make \$150 to \$200 a day." And obviously, these big spenders are asking him about their finances, wondering if they're going to be secure. Their predictions? It's back to basics, apparently — no more shopping extravagantly for Americans, but things will get better by the middle of next year. Of course you need a \$3-a-minute online psychic to tell you this.

The only psychic with intelligent clients, it would seem, is Amaya Elliot — instead of rising, her business dropped by 50 per cent. This makes perfect sense, because in times of economic crisis, intelligent people know that the first thing you do is eliminate extraneous expenses. Like online psychics. And this is the country leading the world's economic charge?

Oddly enough, none of these psychics expected all this success.

GAMER DUMB

Gaming Not Good For Brain

Before we begin this story, we must first express our deep regrets to the following groups of people: 1. Ye whose parents control your gaming time, for you

People Who Changed Computing

John Cocke

You'll like what John Cocke did for your smartphone. He didn't design touchscreens or keypads, but RISC — Reduced Instruction Set Computing — which lays the groundwork for your phone processor's architecture. RISC architectures make



processors more efficient at processing mathematical calculations, and hence finds its place in cell phones, game consoles and to some extent, graphics cards.

A PhD in Mathematics from Duke University, Cocke spent his entire career from 1956 to 1992 as an industrial researcher with IBM. One of his most significant achievements was the IBM 801, which came from his idea to build a very small and very fast core, and which didn't have too many instructions in the instruction set. His work on the 801 won Cocke the Turing Award and the Presidential Medal of Science.

Cocke also co-invented the Cocke-Younger-Kasami (CYK) algorithm, which is one of the more effective algorithms for making computers understand human speech.